

The objectification of identity across events

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Abstract

This paper describes one way in which students develop durable, classroom-specific identities. When students enter new groups their identities are often fluid. Over time, however, students and teachers generally come to identify individuals in predictable ways. Durable identities emerge across events, as signs of identity come to presuppose a consistent trajectory of identification for a given individual. This paper traces the social identification of one student across the course of a two-month curriculum unit in a middle school science class, showing how he developed a complex but robust identity across several weeks in a new lab group.

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1. Introduction

The articles in this volume study objectification as a process. We move beyond posited objects—like “culture,” “identity” or “mind”—as the basic units of analysis for language and social life, focusing instead on the processes through which such objects come into being and remain stable (following, e.g., Bickhard, 1994; Csordas, 1994). I focus on the objectification of social identity, describing how students come to be identified in stable ways over time. This happens as students and others consistently apply models of identity to a focal student, by deploying signs of identity that index relevant models—a process that has been described by linguistic anthropologists over several decades (Agha, 2007; Gumperz, 1982; Silverstein, 1992; Wortham, 2006).

I argue that the objectification of social identity occurs at multiple “timescales” (Lemke, 2000). A student can be identified within a speech event. Whenever a participant enters a speech event, his or her identity is potentially in play. The participant might have had some stable identity going into the event, and everyone might act as if that identity is the relevant one for the current event. Even in such cases, participants do work as they deploy signs indexing the stable identity. But participants often must confront indeterminacy in their own and others’ identities, when they encounter signs that might index various identities (Garfinkel, 1967). In such cases a more stable identity often emerges over the course of the interaction, as participants deploy signs that come increasingly to presuppose some identity for the focal individual (Silverstein, 1992). A less well-known type of objectification occurs across speech events as individuals come to be identified in stable ways over time in local settings (Wortham, 2006). The social identities of individuals in a local setting like a classroom are often indeterminate for longer than one speech event. A student entering a classroom might become a jock, a burnout, a teacher’s pet, a nerd, or various other recognizable types, and several

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of these identities might be in play over days, weeks or months before participants come to identify the individual in stable and predictable ways. The processes through which an individual becomes identified across events in a local setting also constitute the objectification of social identity, and they cannot be reduced to objectification that occurs within events.

Of course, objectification of identity that occurs at the event level is related to objectification that occurs across days, weeks or months in a local setting. Participants and analysts cannot understand what happens within an event without presupposing models of identity that have been established over longer timescales. We might not be able to understand what you meant when you called that student a “jerk” just now, for instance, unless we also know how he has been treated in preceding events. On the other hand, participants and analysts cannot know what trajectory of identification is emerging for a particular student without attending to the details of the events that comprise that trajectory, and discrete events can be pivotal in determining the course of individuals’ trajectories. In order to understand how students develop durable identities, then, we must understand how the objectification of identity occurs both within and across events, and how these different types of objectification interrelate.

I explore these issues by examining how the local social identity of one middle school student emerges, solidifies, and then re-forms over two months in a science classroom. I use data from the same set as other authors in this volume, drawn from the study of a middle school science classroom by Kuipers, Viechnicki and their colleagues at George Washington University. The objectification of the focal student’s social identity happens as predictable models of identity come consistently to be presupposed for him, but this process involves more than just the habitual application of stable social models. The analysis shows how the objectification of identity is complex, with event-level and weeks-long processes of objectification playing important roles, and with varied resources used to accomplish these two sorts of identification. The paper also shows how this objectification depends on conceptual and physical resources particular to science classrooms, including resources drawn from the curriculum. Thus the paper shows how the objectification of academic subject matter and the objectification of classroom identities can interrelate, when the emergence of a stable social identity is facilitated by academic resources.

2. Entextualization within events

Normally, categories of social identity come consistently to apply to a student in a classroom, such that others in the room can reliably identify that student as being a certain kind of person. People have proposed psychological, social, linguistic and other objects to explain why this occurs, and many of these explanations have some truth. People do have stable tendencies as individuals, societies do have readily available categories of identity and habitual ways of using language are routinely interpreted as predictable indicators of identity. In everyday life we commonly accept one or another of these accounts when identifying someone. From an analytic point of view, however, allegedly stable psychological, social and linguistic objects do not suffice to explain identification in practice. As Garfinkel (1967), Goffman (1981), Silverstein (1992) and others have pointed out, people are often identified in ways that violate what one would expect, if one inferred from personality, social categories and/or linguistic regularities. In practice, social identification is an accomplishment that cannot be explained solely with reference to psychological, social or linguistic objects.

Silverstein (1992, 1993) and Silverstein and Urban (1996) offer a more complex account of how signs of identity come to have both expected and unexpected meaning. Their account of “entextualization” can be used to explain how speech comes to identify individuals in practice, in a setting like a classroom. The linguistic and non-linguistic signs that we take as indications of social identity do not rigidly index a given identity. They only come to have more definite meaning over the course of a discursive interaction, as subsequent signs recontextualize or reinforce earlier ones. Someone may have been calling Johnny a “dork” because he is a nerd, but that person may also have been joking, or s/he may even have been trying to break into a high status group by establishing a teasing relationship with someone who is obviously not a nerd. Participants and analysts only know what the sign “dork” meant over time, as subsequent signs come to presuppose one or another of these interpretations. These subsequent signs coalesce into what Silverstein (1992), following Jakobson (1960), calls a “poetic structure” of mutually-presupposing indexical signs that collectively lead participants and analysts to infer how they have been identifying the individual.

In a classroom, then, we cannot assume that students with characteristic personalities, or from certain social backgrounds, or who speak distinctively will inevitably be identified in typical ways. Nor can we assume that use of a given sign of identity has predictable meaning. We must instead investigate how students get identified as events of identification unfold, as signs of identity come to have more definite meaning in the context of subsequent, mutually contextualizing signs. The process of entextualization, thus understood, describes event-level “objectification.” Across the course of an unfolding event a student who might have been identified in various ways comes to be identified in some more definite way. His or her identity becomes more durable and object-like, as various signs accumulate in a mutually-presupposing configuration that comes to establish a more definite identity over the course of the discursive interaction.

3. “The Grab” on February 27

Consider the following example of entextualization. The focal student is “Philip,” an African American middle school student who has recently been moved to a new lab group in science class, in an ethnically and economically diverse suburban school district in the U.S. The other group members are “Gloria,” “Natalie” and “Sean.” Gloria and Natalie are Latinas, and Sean is Anglo. Before Philip was moved into their group, Gloria, Natalie and Sean had established expectations about who would play various roles in the group—who would serve as the group’s spokesperson with the teacher, who would manipulate the lab apparatus, who would insist on working alone and who would look to others for answers, and so on. The arrival of Philip in the group potentially changed these expectations about students’ local identities. The other group members knew some things about Philip: he cared about science and he worked hard in school; he volunteered answers to the teacher’s questions, and the teacher treated him as if he understood science; he had been teased for these behaviors by some other students in the class. But they did not know whether his behavior would remain consistent once he joined the new lab group, nor could they be sure what the interpersonal dynamics in their group would be once he joined. Early in their time together as a group, his local identity solidified within events as certain signs of identity came clearly to presuppose something about who he was as a group member, a student and a peer.

Philip changed groups on February 13. The following interaction happened on February 27. As was typical for this class, students had listened to the teacher give information relevant to the upcoming lab, then to her description of how they were to do the lab. The following transcript begins with the teacher asking students to start the lab.

- T: When you have done both of those ↑thi:↓ngs (.), raise your hand, and I'll come around and check it. [Then you can get ↓started.]
 [((S, G, and P all raise their hands, one following the other))]
 S: (X Excuse me. X)
 5 ? : You're supposed to put zero with the paper towel on ↑it? =
 T: =Yes.
 (6.0) ((other students talking in the background))
 ((P picks up the paper towel then puts it back down))
 S: Ah, might not work [right.]
 10 G: [Plea:se.]
 P: Might work.
 S: It [says]
 P: [That's weird. It says negative XX]
 ((T comes to the table. P's hand is still raised))
 15 ((Gloria zeroes the scale herself))
 P: Wait. (3.0)
 P: Now, we should let-
 T: [K-]
 [((T moves away from the table. P's hand is still raised.))]

- 20 (.)
 [*((P takes the paper towel off of the scale))*]
 S: [No::: =]
 G: =What are you ↑*do:ing*?
 P: We should let (.) we should let it finish, [then (X X X)=]
 25 [*((P puts the paper towel back on the scale))*]
 G: =You stupid *re:tard*.
 [*((G reaches toward the scale with one hand. P grabs her hand. G reaches with her other hand. P blocks her with his hand and arm.))*]
 P: [I need that. Stop.]
 30 S: [Push *ze:ro*.] =
 [*((P zeroes the scale. G tries to twist her hand out of P's grasp.))*]
 P: = [Let me (.) let me figure it out first.]
 G: [Let go (.) let go of my fucking hand.]
 [*((G pulls her hand away))*]
 35 P: (Damn.) I wasn't (.) I wasn't holding your
 hand, idiot. [You] were holding my thumb.=
 G: [↑ What?] ↓Shoot.

At the beginning of this lab activity, the group members do not know how they will position themselves and each other. Because of the social and physical organization of the classroom, some member(s) of the group must interact with the teacher—responding when she expects a response from the group, going to the front of the room to collect materials and asking her questions on behalf of the group. Because the lab apparatus permits only one person to manipulate it at any given moment, some member(s) of the group will have to do the actions required in the lab, while others will sit back and complete the worksheet based on the results others obtain. Since Philip is new to the group, they do not yet know whether he be the conduit to the teacher and the person to manipulate the apparatus, and, if (as it turns out) he does, they do not yet know whether Gloria, Natalie and Sean will allow this.

At line 2, Sean, Gloria and Philip all raise their hands in response to the teacher's request. Philip does so only after noticing that the others have raised their hands. With this act, all three students are positioning themselves as potentially the group's conduit to the teacher. At line 8, Philip lifts up the paper towel sitting on top of the scale. Both Sean and Gloria react immediately at lines 9–10, apparently discouraging Philip from touching the apparatus, and Philip puts the paper towel back on the scale. At line 13 Philip says "it says negative." He is puzzled because, with the paper towel removed, the electronic scale registered a negative number as the weight. (This happened because the scale had been zeroed with the paper towel on top). At line 15 Gloria leans in and pushes a button on the scale, zeroing it herself now that Philip has put the paper towel back on top. Philip says "wait" and then at line 21 takes the paper towel back off the scale. His intentions are unclear here. It could be that he does not understand Gloria has just zeroed the scale and prepared them for the subsequent task. It could be that he does not want to let Gloria be the one to zero the scale, but instead wants to do it himself. He may also have been puzzled by the negative reading that had appeared before and trying to understand why that happened.

Whatever Philip's intentions, Sean and Gloria react as if he is disrupting the group's activity at lines 22–23. Sean says "no;," and Gloria asks Philip what he is doing. From their point of view, Gloria's zeroing the scale had set them up to begin the lab, but Philip unproductively continues to experiment with removing the paper towel. At line 24 Philip zeroes the scale with the paper towel removed and then replaces it. Gloria reacts verbally and physically, both calling him a "retard" and reaching in to zero the scale again with the paper towel on top. At this point in the interaction Sean and Gloria have lined up together against Philip. They have a substantive disagreement about lab procedure, with Sean and Gloria acting as if the group should zero the scale with the paper towel on and Philip acting as if they should zero it with the paper towel off. Sean and Gloria are also resisting Philip's bid to be in control of the lab apparatus. By picking up the paper towel twice, and by re-zeroing it after Gloria did, Philip has acted as if he has the right to manipulate the group's apparatus.

Philip's identity as a member of the group is at issue here, in two respects. First, what is his position in the group? Does he have the right to control the group's apparatus? Second, how competent is he as a student? Does he understand the lab activity well enough to zero the scale properly? These two issues are related, because Sean and Gloria seem to be arguing that he is incompetent as a student and thus cannot be trusted to run the group's lab apparatus.

At line 27, Philip physically stops Gloria from reaching the scale and re-zeroing it with the paper towel on top. He grabs her right wrist with his right hand, before she can reach the scale. She then reaches her left hand forward, and he

places both their right hands in the way, blocking her access. But he immediately uses his left hand to zero the scale with the paper towel on top. His action is deliberate and assured, and he does not correct it subsequently, so it looks as if Philip has accepted Gloria and Sean's approach to zeroing the scale. Gloria and Sean also act as if the scale is now zeroed properly. They make no attempts to re-zero it, even when Philip gets up and leaves the table several seconds later. (By line 27, at least, Philip seems to understand that the scale needs to be zeroed with the towel on top. He may have understood this all along. Unlike Gloria and Sean, he was also interested in figuring out why the scale gave a negative reading earlier, without the towel on top. By zeroing the scale with the towel on top at line 31 he abandons this sideline exploration and begins the assigned lab activity.)

Even though the dispute about zeroing the scale is over, questions about Philip's position in the group, and perhaps his competence as a student, remain. From lines 27–34, Philip was holding Gloria's right hand and was blocking her left hand from reaching the scale. After Gloria extricates her hand at line 35, Philip moves his torso forward over the table and places his forearm on the table between Gloria and the scale. He also says "let me figure it out first" at line 32. With these actions Philip continues to act as if he is in charge of the group's lab apparatus, empowered to manipulate it as he sees fit. Gloria has both verbally and physically challenged Philip's claim, and the question remains at line 37: will Gloria and Sean allow Philip to position himself as controller of the lab apparatus?

In fact, they do, as we can see in the next segment.

- G: (Don't) touch me. Eww= now I got diseases and (X).=
P: <You touched me.>
40 P: I'd walk. I'd try to get (.) [↑away.] [You touched me.]
G: [I didn't] [touch you.]=
G: =Why would I want to touch you?=
P: = [Why were you] grabbing my thumb, smart-?
P: [(Tst.) To get sick?]
45 (.)
G: You were grabbing my h↑a↓nd. I was trying to let go, and you wouldn't let
[go. So I had to (.) I had to (X)] your thumb (X).=
P: [I was not grabbing your hand.]
G: =Stupid a:ss
50 P: I did not grab your [(.) I did not grab (XX).]
G: [Shut the fuck up. ((G closes her lab manual and
throws across the table. N puts it in a neat pile with her own manual))]
G: °God (.) damn i:t.°
(4.0)
55 P: (No) (.) [(No)] ((P gets up and walks away from the table))
T: [Make] sure you ↑ba:l it up before you weigh it and then you
spread it out o:ver the top of the scale.
(2.04)
G: °I swear to God. ° (X X). Go tell the fucking teacher, (man). (2.0)
60 G: [EW. See look how he left my hand yo, look at this.]
[(((G abruptly drops her pen and wipes her right hand with her left))]
(3.6) ((P returns to the table and G picks up her pen again. P puts the steel
wool on the scale. It rolls off and he has to put it back on.))
G: Who knows what he has on [his hands.]
65 S: [°Dumbass. °]
G: (Go:sh) yo.
?: ((in the background)) Tries to (.)
G: Grips on your f↑ing↓ers
(1.2)
70 T: Make sure you write (.) the units ↑down. So you're writing it in grams.
((S, P and N lean forward to read the scale. P writes in his notebook))
N: °Two point (.) two. °
(9.05) ((students talking in the background))
P: (Mm, k) ((P takes something off of the scale))
75 G: Sexual harassment.

Before line 51, and starting before the beginning of the first transcript, Gloria has had a lab manual in front of her, neatly opened and folded back to the appropriate page. She also has a stack of papers for note-taking and a pen. Philip also has an open lab manual, a stack of papers and a pen. Sean and Natalie have only papers and pens, but no lab manuals open in front of them—although there are extra manuals, closed and available on the table. Sean and Natalie are also sitting at the corners of the table furthest away from the front of the scale. They cannot see what the scale reads, and so they will have to rely on Philip or Gloria to tell them the results of the lab activity. Gloria and Philip, then, have positioned themselves as most involved and most in control of the lab activity. But at line 51, after Philip has physically blocked her from touching the scale, Gloria gives up on following the lab instructions herself when she closes and throws her lab manual across the table toward the unused manuals that presumably belong to Sean and Natalie. From this point on, Gloria allows Philip to be the only group member who follows procedures in the lab manual and manipulates the apparatus. At line 55 Philip also goes up and gets the steel wool that will be part of the group's lab apparatus for the day—thus establishing himself in another way as the one in charge of managing the group's lab activity.

After line 51, then, Philip has successfully identified himself as the group member in charge of the apparatus. At the beginning of the lab session, it was unclear whether he would be able to occupy this position, because both Gloria and Sean contested his attempts. But he perseveres, and Gloria unhappily acknowledges his position with her action at line 51 and with her acquiescence thereafter. This does not mean that Philip's social identity in the lab group is settled, however. Being in charge of the apparatus and serving as the conduit to the teacher can be important aspects of a student's identity in a lab group, but they are not the only ones. In Philip's case, his identity as a student and his identity as a peer both remain at issue.

Both before and after line 51, Gloria and Sean identify Philip as a bad student and an untrustworthy source of information about their academic tasks. During their dispute over how to zero the scale, Gloria called Philip a "retard" (at line 26). With his comments at lines 9, 22 and 30, Sean told Philip what to do and implied that he did not understand how to zero a scale correctly. As noted above, this denigration of his academic capabilities was probably related to their attempt to stop him from controlling the group's lab activity—which they thought he was botching. But Gloria and Sean continue to denigrate Philip's intelligence after they have allowed him to manage the group's lab apparatus. At line 65, for instance, Sean calls Philip a "dumbass" when he inadvertently lets the steel wool roll of the scale. If they really thought he was academically incompetent (which he is not), they probably would not have allowed him to run this and other lab activities for the group. They are more likely denigrating his intelligence as part of their ongoing identification of him as a type of person.

Philip's identity as a peer is at issue in this interaction. These students have many possible models available to identify each other—as "cool," as "nerds," as "burnouts," as "outcasts," as "hot," and very large number of other possibilities—models drawn both from the specific institution of schooling and from the larger culture. Gloria and Philip engage in a dispute over what happened—did Philip grab her, or did she grab him—and this dispute has implications for who Philip is as a boy and an adolescent peer in the classroom. In the course of this dispute, Gloria escalates the description of what happened, from Philip's description of "hand holding" (line 35) to "touching" (38, 40) to "grabbing" (43, 46, etc.) to "gripping" (68) to "sexual harassment" (75). She continues to complain about his having touched her hand, for several minutes (from lines 33–152). In the segment above (at lines 38 and 64), she complains about his having diseases and being dirty. She also curses at him and becomes visibly angry at lines 51–53.

By describing their physical contact in these ways, Gloria identifies Philip and herself as recognizable types of people. Instead of focusing on the issue of which student controls the apparatus, she shifts to the issue of what kind of peer Philip is. Perhaps Gloria shifts from focusing on the lab activity to characterizing Philip's identity as a peer because she has lost the struggle for control of the apparatus and she wants to get even by attributing a negative peer identity to him. Perhaps she also wants to head off misinterpretation of the physical contact that she and Philip had. "Holding hands," if that is what they were doing, may indicate some romantic interest. Other students, and perhaps Philip himself, might claim that their "hand holding" had implications for their relationship. Gloria demolishes that possible interpretation as quickly as she can.

One might object that this reads too much about romantic involvement into a simple grab. But these students are adolescents. Gloria and her friends say something in almost every class to indicate that they think of boys in the class as potential romantic partners, or that they want the boys to think of them as potential partners. In another class session, for instance, Gloria, Natalie and a friend have the following exchange.

- N: Yea:h he looks so different.
 G: You left my table too.
 N: I'm serious he loo- he's so tall.
 N: He's hot now, I'm serious.
 5 N: Oh he's <X been X>.
 L: We were ice- we went ice skating XX.
 N: Oh my [gosh.]
 G: [She's like < he's so hot now >.]
 N: [He has not changed].
 10 N: He has not- no everybody in elementary
 school thought he was hot so, nothing new. And like
 when you look at him he look- man you should see him.

According to Natalie and Gloria, some boys are “hot.” On another occasion Gloria sang, loudly enough for the class to hear, “I need a boyfriend, I need a boyfriend.” Thus she has made clear that she is interested in romantic relationships with boys, or at least that she wants to flirt with boys about the possibility of romantic relationships.

After Philip grabs her hand on February 27, however, she makes it clear that he is not a boy she would even consider. At lines 38 and 60–64, she talks about the kinds of diseases she might have contracted from touching Philip. She also calls him an “ass” (line 49) and tells him to “shut the fuck up” (51). Thus Gloria distinguishes clearly between the kind of boy she might consider as a romantic partner and the kind of boy Philip is. Philip is disgusting, and he can be directly insulted and cursed. Although Gloria may have ceded control over the lab apparatus to Philip, she will not back down in her characterization of him as a low status peer who cannot even be imagined as a romantic partner. Philip initially contests Gloria’s claim that he did the grabbing, from lines 35–50, but from that point on he goes back to the academic task and does not respond to her continued complaints and insults.

At line 75, then, two aspects of Philip’s identity are beginning to solidify. First, he has established himself as the student in control of the lab activity. This aspect of his identity remains stable over the rest of the interaction. Second, Gloria has treated him as a low status peer who can be insulted publicly and whom she would never even consider as a romantic partner. Philip does not contest this, after line 50, until later in the interaction. He could have fought back against Gloria’s insulting talk, or he could have claimed that she protests so much that she really must be romantically interested in him. Depending on others’ reactions, he might have then been identified as a higher status peer. But at line 75 it looks as if Gloria’s characterization of him as a low status peer might stick.

As the interaction continues, Philip continues to struggle against Gloria and Sean, as they try to characterize him as incompetent and prone to academic mistakes.

- S: [Look, you're s'pose] to spread it out [(.)over the thing
 G: [Spose to spread it out
 over that, ↓stup↑id. It's gonna shed. ↓Look ↑it. (X) took all that off.
 (1.4)
 80 P: Ok, I'll t- [(.)]I'll ↑ ball it up.
 G: [hh]
 P: We can [re- do it.] Make sure that [(XX)]
 G: [What are]" you- ? (.) hh = [Now you]shedded m↑o↓re. You're
 so- (.) now it's two point ↑o↓ne.
 85 P: Well-

The experiment is to weigh a piece of steel wool all balled up, then stretch it out and weigh it again—thus testing to see whether mass is conserved through changes in shape. Gloria and Sean claim (correctly) that in stretching out the steel wool Philip let some small pieces fall off, thus changing the second reading and making it seem as if mass was lost. Philip acts as if it was an honest mistake and proceeds to re-do the experiment, while Gloria calls him “stupid.” Although Gloria and Sean do not try to take over the lab apparatus, they do continue to insult Philip’s intelligence. Although this could be teasing, given the strength of Gloria’s displeasure over losing control of the apparatus and over being grabbed, it is more likely a serious insult that undermines Philip’s status as a peer.

Later in the lab, Gloria and Natalie switch into Spanish and Gloria complains about Philip some more. Neither Philip nor Sean understands Spanish, and they ignore the girls during this time. For them, the talk in Spanish simply excludes them from the interaction and shows that Gloria and Natalie have a bond with each other. For Gloria and

Natalie, their talk keeps Philip's identity as a low status, annoying person salient. Gloria switches back into English in the following segment, continuing to identify Philip as stupid and low status.

- (5.25) ((*P returns to table, puts paper towel on scale.*))
 S: We don't need the paper towel any ↓more.
 (4.18) ((*P takes the paper towel off the scale and it flutters to the floor. He picks it up.*))
- 135 G: Dummy.
 (1.99)
 G: He has no control over his ↓finge↑rs. Ha ha ha.
 P: Ok↑a↓y.
 G: Ha ha ha. ((*G drops her pen and pulls her hair back.*))
- 140 (3.0)
 T: U:::hm.
 N: Ok, then one, two.
 P: If I had no control over my fingers how could I do this? ((*P twirls his pencil in his hand as if it were a cheerleader's baton.*))
- 145 G: (.) Cause you're retarded.
 P: No.

At line 143, Philip has apparently had enough, and he tries to fight back against Gloria's insults. His small display of manual dexterity does not impress her or anyone else, however. Gloria calls him "retarded" at line 145, and neither Sean nor anyone else defends him. At the end of the interaction, then, Philip's identity as a low status peer seems relatively solid.

This analysis of the discursive interaction on February 27 shows how objectification occurs at the level of individual events. When the students began their lab activity on that day, they did not know what kind of person Philip was going to be. Was he going to be in charge of the lab activities? Was he intelligent? Was he a respectable and perhaps even a desirable peer? Over the course of the interaction, it became clear that Philip was in charge of the lab activity and that he was a low status, undesirable peer. These aspects of Philip's identity could have turned out differently. Sean could have taken Gloria's side and together they might have insisted that Gloria run the lab. Sean and Natalie could have joined Philip and teased Gloria about how much she must have enjoyed holding Philip's hand. But these things did not happen, and across the event Philip's identity as in charge of the lab and as low status became more durable.

The participants used various resources to accomplish this event-level objectification of Philip's identity. They deployed highly presupposing signs, like Gloria's cursing of Philip, in public, to his face. They indexed publicly circulating models of personhood, like the model of "good" students as ones who quickly understand new tasks and complete them without effort or confusion. They were constrained by the physical layout of the task, which afforded only one person control over the apparatus. And they were constrained by the curriculum and classroom organization, which specified one right answer to the lab questions and rewarded students for quickly reaching that answer. All these resources, and others, helped them identify Philip as in control and as low status. Entextualization, then, is a type of objectification that takes place within speech events, across minutes and hours, and that depends on heterogeneous resources.

4. Interdiscursivity

Social identity, however, does not get established only within events. However Philip might have been identified across those few minutes on February 27, that event could have been an aberration, or his local social identity might have shifted after that point. I have argued elsewhere, following Dreier (2000) and Agha (2003, 2007), that social identification is best conceived across a trajectory of events (Wortham, 2005, 2006). Just as one comment in an interaction can turn out to be uncharacteristic or irrelevant to the identification of an individual within a speech event, as subsequent signs come to presuppose a different identity for the focal individual, the identity that becomes entextualized within an event can turn out to be uncharacteristic or irrelevant across events. Sometimes individuals are consistently identified, of course, and sometimes one event is pivotal for the lasting social identification of an individual. In such cases analyses of single events can suffice. In general, however, individuals' identities emerge

across trajectories of events and we must trace this emergence over time. Whoever Philip may have become during the interaction on February 27, we need to examine his social identity development on other days as well. This requires studying the objectification of identity across time, as various potential trajectories of identification get narrowed down and as a more stable identity emerges for the individual. This is a different type of objectification, not within events but across them.

This sort of objectification across events has been described recently as “interdiscursive” (Agha, 2007; Agha & Wortham, 2005). In addition to examining the entextualization accomplished within events, phenomena like the formation of registers (Agha, 2003), socialization and social identification (Wortham, 2005) require that we examine chains or trajectories of signs across events. Events are linked to each other, as signs in neighboring events index each other, and these linkages facilitate social identification and other important social processes. Social identification can occur across an interdiscursively linked trajectory of events, as models of personhood become more rigidly linked to an individual. Object-like social identities, then, are accomplished not only through entextualization within events but also through interdiscursive trajectories across events, as models of personhood emerge and come to characterize individuals.

In Philip’s case, we have data across more than two months, from about a week before he entered the group with Sean, Gloria and Natalie to the end of the curriculum unit in early April. Thus we can only examine the emergence of identity across these weeks, without knowing about the trajectories Philip followed before February, after the curriculum unit or outside of this classroom. Nonetheless, the detailed data on Philip across two months reveal trajectories of identification which illustrate how objectification can occur interdiscursively as well as within events.

5. Philip’s identity before “The Grab”

On February 6, about a week before Philip changed lab groups, members of his original group teased and denigrated him, in ways like the following.

- L: Two was-
 Q: We can do it [how we-]
 P: [If we do that-] if we did it
 systematically we are more likely to find
 5 something that's going to do something.
 O: Oh, big words.
 P: Systematically is not a big word,
 [it only has three] syllables.
 L: [For me it is.]
 10 P: X
 Q: See, I told you he's a loser.
 P: X, Huh?
 Q: Nothing.
 P: I'll go toss it.
 15 Q: Okay, you do that. He's a loser, nobody likes him.

Here Oliver and Quintin pick on Philip for suggesting better ways to do the lab and for using “big words” to explain his suggestions. This sort of cruel treatment may have been one of the reasons that the teacher switched Philip into a new group.

When Philip entered the new group on February 13, Sean, Gloria and Natalie knew that Philip had been treated as a low status peer by Oliver and Quintin—because the lab tables were close together and these boys had not done their teasing quietly. From whole class discussions, the new lab group also knew that Philip often answered the teacher’s questions and that the teacher recognized him as a good student. Philip’s social identity in the new lab group was nonetheless somewhat indeterminate. Would Sean, Gloria and Natalie continue to treat him as a low status peer? The earlier teasing had come from the boys in his group. Would Sean be friendlier than Oliver and Quintin? Would Gloria and Natalie feel empowered to denigrate him so much? Would this new group value his academic contributions more, since they apparently cared more than Oliver and Quintin about succeeding in school?

On February 13, Philip, Gloria and Natalie cooperated in a lab activity. Gloria starts out in the first line questioning Philip, who has been manipulating the lab apparatus. But the interaction goes very differently than it did on February 27.

- G: What are you doing?
 N: The next- one, vinegar and baking soda.
 P: What? I got the next thing that we need.
 N: [X X X]
- 5 P: [We're not supp-] we're just supposed to leave that alone for now.
 N: Oh yeah we have to wait every-
 P: So we go- go do- we do the next one.
 G: We didn't even finish the first one.
- 10 N: No we have to- that's- we have to do, the [second one now.]
 P: [We're supposed to] do the sec- second one. We're supposed to do the rest of them while this one's X. This one's just bad.
- 15 N: Very clear X.

At lines 3 and 5, Philip explains what the group should be doing, and at line 7 Natalie accepts his explanation. Gloria objects at line 9, but Natalie then takes Philip's side at line 10. At line 15, where she is making an observation about the color of the experimental liquid, Natalie continues to engage in the experiment with Philip. Philip, Natalie and Gloria use "we" in this segment to refer to them together as a lab group. They act as if they care about doing the lab correctly and as if they are a cohesive group working toward that goal. Gloria is somewhat less committed to the activity than Natalie, and as they proceed she makes a joke or two, but Natalie keeps working on the lab with Philip. The group was working so well together, in fact, that the teacher comes by and says "I love when I am hearing people reading the directions from the lab manual to each other."

On February 13, then, Philip, Gloria and Natalie cooperate. They act as if they all care about doing the lab, and as if Philip is a member of the group working toward that end. This makes Philip's local identity in the new lab group potentially very different than it had been in his prior group the week before. He is identified here as a good student who is valued by others for his intelligence and his attention to the lab activity. As he did on February 27, Philip controls the lab apparatus on February 13. Gloria responds to this in a couple of places by asking "what are you doing," even though she does not press the issue. Later in the interaction Gloria and Natalie also talk to each other more than to Philip. So the girls do not treat Philip as a friend or as an equal partner in the lab activity. They nonetheless engage productively with him when he does something successful in the lab activity, when they are excited about the outcome of an experiment or when they want academic information from him.

This pattern continued, during February and intermittently into March. Sean and Natalie let Philip run lab activities, and they often looked to Philip for the right answers. Before the grab incident on February 27, Gloria also sometimes treated Philip this way. There are also events, however, in which Gloria, Natalie and Sean treat Philip as incompetent. On February 14, for instance, Gloria and Natalie disagree with Philip.

- G: Oh, so that is what it's doing, it's evaporating.
 P: Not really.
 G: Yes it is.
 P: I don't think it's- it's separating.
- 5 N: That's what it's called.
 G: That's what she just said. Yeah, is we're sending some of this stuff up to the air so it's evaporating stupid.
 P: But water evaporates, it's still water. It separates. It's seperating into hydrogen and oxygen.
- 10 G: No:, they're separating and some of stuff is just-
 N: Even Ms. Teacher says evaporating.
 G: X God, he's a dumbass.

Gloria and Natalie disagree with Philip over the appropriate terminology here. Instead of offering further arguments for her position, however, Gloria simply calls Philip "stupid" and a "dumbass."

Although Gloria persists with such comments about Philip's intelligence, especially after February 27, the teacher consistently throws her support behind Philip as a good student. Gloria does not like this. But she can only snipe at

Philip once the teacher has anointed him as academically successful. The following interaction, from February 14, shows this dynamic.

- T: What's going to happen eventually if we leave the pencils in there hooked up to this electricity?
 P: It'll just dissolve the water
 N: There won't be any more water.
 5 T: Where would it all go?
 N: XXX.
 P: [Air.]
 G: [The air.]
 N: [The air.]
 10 T: It will all evaporate as what?
 N: [Air.]
 P: [Hydrogen and oxygen.]
 T: What specifically?
 G: [Vapor, water.]
 15 N: Air.
 P: Gases.
 T: What two gases?
 P: Hydrogen and oxygen, I just said that.
 T: Okay I am glad you know. I am asking Gloria [and Natalie
 20 too], I want to make sure everyone knows, okay?
 P: [Oh, sorry.]

The teacher makes clear here that Philip had the right answer, but also that she does not think the girls understand. She goes on to extract the answer from the girls.

In response, Gloria and Natalie speak unflatteringly about Philip, in Spanish, with Natalie saying about Philip “Medio lacro, no se quiere callar (Kind of annoying, he does not want to shut up).” Gloria and Natalie cannot change the teacher’s relative evaluation of them and Philip, but they can characterize Philip as an obnoxious know-it-all. Later in that same class session, after Philip gets up and moves away from the table, Gloria gestures toward his empty seat and tells Natalie that “he stinks.” She also makes clear through body language that she did not consider him a peer worth interacting with. When she had to sit in the empty seat beside Philip on February 25, for instance, she rolled her eyes and oriented her entire body away from him. Before February 27, then, Gloria and Natalie sometimes treated Philip as low status, but they were not as explicit or as public as Oliver and Quintin had been in identifying Philip this way.

6. Philip’s identity after “The Grab”

On February 27, as we have seen, Gloria responded to the grab by explicitly and vehemently identifying Philip as a low status peer. Philip now had to contend with explicitly face-threatening comments from Gloria, whereas her earlier insults had been less public, shorter and more easily ignored. He sometimes tried to defend himself. Right after the grab (at line 35) he claimed that she was the one holding his hand, but Gloria silenced him with “shut the fuck up.” In response to Gloria’s claim that he had no control over his fingers (at line 143) Philip demonstrated his manual dexterity by twirling a pencil, but Gloria silenced him with “you’re retarded.” So Gloria’s insults identified Philip as pathetic and as low status, and he was unable to fight back.

Gloria acted in similar ways for the rest of the curriculum unit. On March 3, for instance, Gloria asks Natalie a question but Philip answers instead.

- G: When?
 P: Last class.
 G: Shut up, nobody was talking to you. Thinks someone was talking to him. [Who was saying your name? Nobody.]
 5 P: [That damn noise you X babbling.]

On March 6, Philip addresses Gloria without using her name, and she responds:

- G: Oh. Don't you know my name?
 P: I- I forget names and faces.
 G: Oh. I wish I could forget yours.
 P: What?
 5 G: I wish I could forget yours.

Higher status peers would not be addressed this way, or would not tolerate it if they were, but Gloria feels free to talk like this to Philip.

Here is one more example, which occurred on March 31, from among the many times that Gloria insulted Philip directly. The group is working in pairs, the girls and the boys, using kits to construct molecules. Gloria refuses to give the boys what they need.

- S: Try making a water molecule.
 P: Okay I get it.
 N: X X Gloria
 S: We need one of those reds.
 5 N: Gloria
 G: Too bad huh?
 N: Mira
 [Look]
 P: At least one. Well, we can't make a molecule without the-
 10 G: Oo.
 P: Plea:se give us- the rest of the reds.
 G: Oxygen is red.
 P: So it'd be nice to have the red so- [we can finish D.]
 G: [Yes. That's right.] Hey
 15 give me that. X X X X. X X That's cool.
 N: Esperate. Ya le voy a pegar.
 [Wait. I'm gonna hit him now]
 N: Psst. X X
 S: How are we supposed to do it if we only have one stick?
 20 P: Two.
 G: Oh-
 N: @ @ @.
 G: Ha ha. Ha ha. Ha ha.
 P: I think we need the other stick to [X X X.]
 25 G: [Too bad.]
 P: Be nice if I can get [a little cooperation.]
 G: [Shut up.]

In this segment Gloria feels free to deny the boys what they need to complete the assignment. At lines 6 and 25 she responds to Sean and Philip's requests with "too bad," and at line 27 she tells Philip to "shut up." By treating Philip in this insulting way, Gloria continues to identify him as low status. Whatever status Philip may have gained by controlling the lab activities and being identified as a good student, Gloria makes him pay by consistently identifying him as a low status peer.

This last segment also gives evidence about the other students' roles in identifying Philip. Despite her volubility, Gloria cannot by herself identify Philip as low status. Philip occasionally tries to fight back, but gives up. There are other students and the teacher in the classroom, however, and their reactions also influence Philip's identity. As she does in the last segment, at line 16, Natalie generally goes along with Gloria's treatment of Philip. She certainly does not object, and she sometimes speaks to Gloria in Spanish about Philip. On March 13, for instance, Natalie responds to one of Philip's comments with "Quien le pregunta a este menso (Who's asking this stupid person)." So Natalie does not publicly insult Philip, but she supports Gloria.

Sean, however, is a more complex case. Sean and Philip are both boys, and they are both non-Spanish-speakers, so they are potentially allied against Gloria and Natalie. Philip's peer identity could be very different, depending on Sean's position. Philip could have a conflict with Gloria, but have other friends like Sean whom he could rely on for support and some peer status. He would not be a member of the high status group, but he could nonetheless have a marginally

respectable identity. If Sean were to join Gloria's against Philip, however, Philip would be both derided and alone. This would give him even lower status. On February 27, as we have seen, Sean does join some of Gloria's complaints against Philip and calls him a "dumbass." But Sean did not talk like this very often. He wanted to get the labs done, but he did not take a lead role and he did not interact much with Philip, Gloria and Natalie outside of the practical lab activities.

On March 31, when Gloria tortured both Sean and Philip, she might have brought them closer together. Both Philip and Sean referred to the two of them as "we" in that segment, which may indicate some amount of solidarity. Philip tried to build on this potential solidarity and create a friendlier peer relationship with Sean in late March and early April. On April 4, for instance, Philip tried to start a conversation about aliens.

- P: I wonder if real aliens really exist anyways. And if they
do why haven't we found them? Or the other way around.
S: I think they have a better chance at finding us.
P: Who knows they could- who knows maybe- maybe aliens
5 really are like- have technology [X X]
T: [You don't have to wait for
me after you've made for me account for atoms and balance
your equation.]
S: Oh.

At line 3 Sean responds briefly to Philip's comment. They might have had a more extended conversation and established rapport as peers who are interested in aliens, but the teacher interrupted and they go back to lab activities. On April 9 Philip managed to initiate a more extended conversation.

- P: If you were in a video game would you want to use
magic or- or- X X X?
S: Magic.
P: Personally I'd want to be able to do both.
5 S: Yeah, they should put a game that has both. Like X X X.
P: Yeah. Plenty of games they hav- like you hav- you have
to be ab- be able to- you have to have both fight and magic.
So you may have like- thr- you may have like four to six
peop- four to six people and you want to have something
10 you can run up and beat on people and something you can
sit back and heal or conjure up spells. Or you can conju-
conjure up some demon and that would be alright.
S: Yeah but there's this one X, everyone has both.
N: [Ms. Teacher].
15 P: [I've seen plenty] of games like that, that's like X X,
S: [The magic has-]
P: like they're penalized for using magic because they're not
good at it.
S: the magic has to build up and the magic like- like all of
20 them have- like some magic is used to heal themselves and
some is to kill people.
P: Yeah there's various different kinds of magic. Like earth,
earth- and water are ususally for healing, fire and dark usually
hurt. Light often heals- But all of them can hurt too- almost all
25 of them hurt but usually- usually it's like X. Dark, fire, wind,
and some other things that actually hurt that are- that are- are
geared toward doing X X.
TA: You guys have a question?
P: Hm?
30 TA: You have a question?
P: No.
S: No we-
P: We're getting her to look at it.

Philip initiated and dominates this conversation, but Sean contributed as well. The boys have found a topic that they both care about, and they have a pleasant conversation.

Despite his treating Philip as a respectable peer on April 9, however, Sean did not really become Philip's friend. His friends seemed to be other boys who were interested in sports. Sean sometimes talked about sports with boys from other lab groups. The following segment is from March 31.

- X: [Are the X in the playoffs?]
 S: [Yeah.]
 P: [Yeah.]
 X: When do the playoffs start?
 5 S: I think next week.
 X: Who are they playing?
 S: Um:: I don't know.
 X: Are you going to any games?
 S: I don't know.
 10 P: That's wh-
 S: I think I'm going to one on Thursday but it's not the playoffs.
 X: You are though?
 S: Yeah.

Despite Philip's attempts to break in, Sean and his friend do not include him in the conversation. Philip was someone who could talk about aliens and video games, and sometimes Sean talked with him about such topics. But when it came to sports, Philip apparently was not welcome in the conversation. So Philip's bid to change his peer identity by making friends with Sean was only marginally successful.

Right before the conversation about video games, something else important happened in the relationship between Philip and Sean. On April 7, Philip made an academic mistake that angered Sean and prodded him into a more active role.

- G: Randall come here. I need help.
 R: Hm?
 G: I need help. What'd you guys get? We wondered
 how'd you guys get it? Or like whatever you did.
 5 R: You only need one of these, one of each. So, it's just this plus this.
 P: It doesn't work.
 R: Yeah it does.
 P: You have five A's.
 R: Because you have enough stuff here to make all three of these.
 10 P: It doesn't- it's not balanced.
 R: Yeah it is.
 P: How's five equal four?
 R: You can't count.
 N: @@@.
 15 G: XXX.
 S: X we had a counting error. Because this only- there's three O's,
 XX five O's, how many do we need?
 P: XXX H's.
 S: One two three four five. You drew an extra O over here.
 20 P: Where? Where did I draw an extra O?
 G: Ya le dijo.
 [Already told him.]
 P: Water.
 S: H two one O.
 25 P: Oh I got it backwards.
 S: @@ ah.
 P: Okay.
 S: If it wasn't for that we would have had it done like an hour
 ago. Okay, we're done.
 30 P: Didn't take an hour, but this class isn't- I don't think is-
 is even an hour long.
 S: We just spent like half an hour it.
 G: I know, right.
 S: For a written error.
 35 G: Oh my god this pissed me off.

At line 16 Sean realizes that the group has made an error, which Randall's explanation has made clear. He initially says that "we" made the error, but he quickly switches to "you" at line 19 and attributes the error to Philip. Sean goes on at lines 28–34 to accuse Philip of costing the group lots of time, and Gloria piles on at line 35.

A few seconds later Sean intervenes more forcefully than he has done in the past, correcting another mistake by Philip.

- S: Huh?
P: Vinegar doesn't make sense. C H C O O H?
45 S: There were- that's the way that it's like written.
See like, [there's C] there and then O O H.
P: [That's screwed up.] You pull
them together. There's two. It's O two.
S: No it's not! [It's not O two.]
50 P: [Yeah, that's how-] that's how it always goes.
S: No it's not O two, because there are two O's, and
O- two O's is not the same as O two.
P: Sure they are.
S: No they're not.
55 P: Well hey, there's two O's here, so that would be O two. It's the
same thing with H. H two O. They're not attached to each other,
they're attached to the O.
S: You want to see what this thing says?
P: That thing's screwed up.
60 S: No it's not. [Idiot.]

At line 60, Sean calls Philip an "idiot," which echoes Gloria's earlier comments. But Sean relies more on reason than on insults here. He explains at line 52 that "two O's is not the same as O two," and he goes on to cite the textbook for support.

On April 7, then, Sean challenges Philip's position as the lead student in the group. Sean acts as if he understands the material better than Philip, and he expresses anger and outrage that Philip's error has cost the group half an hour of effort and frustration. This could have been just a passing burst of activity on Sean's part, but in fact he went on to adopt a more active position in the group on April 8 as well. Perhaps he managed to do this because he was male, or because Philip made a serious mistake on April 7, or because Philip cared more about Sean's opinion than he did about Gloria's. Whatever the reason, this shift might have had implications for Philip's identity. If Sean had continued to take control of the lab group in subsequent days, Philip might have become a more passive observer instead of the group's conduit to the teacher. If Natalie, Gloria and even Philip himself had started to ask Sean for the right answers, and/or if the teacher had begun to look to Sean as the group's most academically promising member, perhaps Philip would have lost his identity as a particularly good student.

Thus Philip's trajectory might have shifted in early April, with respect to his local social identity as an academically strong student in charge of the lab group. Over his first month and a half with the new group Philip was generally recognized by teacher and students as an academically successful student, despite Gloria's challenges. But Philip's public mistake on April 7, and Sean's new, active role in noting this mistake and taking control of the group might have altered Philip's identity as a student. Philip's attempts on April 4 and 9 to be friendly with Sean might also have changed the dynamics and altered Philip's social identity. In fact, however, we do not know whether Philip's trajectory of identification shifted, because the curriculum unit ended shortly after April 9. He might have lost his position as the alpha student to Sean, he might have fought off Sean's challenge, Sean might have gone back to his former position, or Philip and Sean might have developed a new relationship and new identities as they became friends and jointly ran the lab activities.

Philip's trajectory of identification, then, began with extremely harsh treatment from Oliver and Quintin—who identified him as smart but a "loser" whom nobody likes—and then with the move to the new lab group. In his first two weeks in the new lab group, Philip did not confront many face-threatening attacks, even though Gloria did insult him in small ways. His identity as a peer was somewhat indeterminate, although the residue of Oliver and Quintin's treatment remained. Starting with "the grab" on February 27, and throughout the rest of the curriculum unit, Gloria more aggressively identified Philip as low status by insulting him in public. Natalie accepted this identification of Philip, although she did not join Gloria in making public comments. Philip tried and failed to fight back against Gloria,

who overwhelmed him with insults. Sean initially played a small role in supporting Gloria, but for the first month he did not say much to or about Philip. Beginning in mid-March, Philip tried to be friendly with Sean, talking to him about aliens and video games. Sean ignored him for a while, but at the very end of the unit he sometimes acted in a more friendly way toward Philip. Philip's emerging relationship with Sean did not overcome his identity as a low status peer, but it had the potential to make him a more respectable low-to-middle status person who had his place among male friends, instead his being a "loser" without any friends.

7. Objectification across timescales

The class on February 27 was representative of Philip's social identity in his new lab group, in some ways. Gloria struggled but failed to wrest control of the lab group from Philip and Gloria identified Philip as a low status peer by insulting him in public. In fact, this class session was a turning point in Philip's trajectory. With his "grab" Philip physically defended his role as in charge of the lab apparatus, a position that he occupied until the end of the unit. Before February 27, Philip's low status peer identity had also been muted in his new lab group. Starting on that day, however, Gloria began a vocal campaign to insult Philip and remind everyone of his low status. The analysis of the February 27 class shows how these various aspects of Philip's identity were entextualized or objectified over several minutes in one speech event. Central aspects of Philip's local identity emerged across this interaction, and these aspects of his identity could have emerged differently on that day.

The subsequent analyses of the trajectories across which various aspects of Philip's identity emerged, however, show that the event on February 27 did not by itself establish Philip's social identity in this classroom. Philip's identity as a good student was contested on February 27, and it took other events for this aspect of his identity to solidify. If the teacher had not treated Philip as an academically successful student across February and March, and if Natalie and Sean had not also treated him this way, Philip's identity as a good student would not have become as solid as it did. His trajectory of identification as a good student became more rigid, as the teacher and the other students positioned him this way across events. Such a trajectory need not involve only signs and events that characterize a person in one way. We have seen that Gloria kept trying to identify Philip as stupid, and sometimes she successfully pointed out mistakes he had made. But the overall direction of the trajectory was toward Philip being identified as a good student, both because of the large number of signs across events that characterized him this way and because of the institutionalized position of the teacher whose positive evaluations of him held more weight. On April 7, of course, Sean's aggressive challenge to Philip's mistake might have shifted the trajectory of Philip's academic identity.

This case has also shown how different trajectories of identification have different shapes. Philip was identified as in charge of the lab group by February 27, when he physically blocked Gloria from touching the scale, after two weeks in which this aspect of his local identity was still somewhat indeterminate. After February 27, the issue was settled. Philip's peer identity was also somewhat indeterminate from his move to the new lab group until February 27, then it was publicly settled for a few weeks, and then Philip may have made friends with Sean. Philip's academic identity was more consistent across the unit, with some short periods of indeterminacy as Gloria and others challenged him, and increasingly solid as the teacher treated Philip as a successful student. Both Philip's identity as a good student and his identity as a low status peer show how trajectories of identification can turn in new directions, as subsequent events allow individuals to be positioned differently. Sean might have eclipsed Philip as the academically dominant student, and Philip might have established himself as a friend of Sean and not merely a lone loser, if the events of early April were followed with similar ones.

Objectification, then, occurs both within events and across them. If there can be more than one type of objectification occurring simultaneously, however, how do they relate? Are there other sorts of objectification, at different timescales? If so, how can analysts know which sorts of objectification are relevant in a given case?

The existence of both event-level and interdiscursive objectification shows that phenomena like social identification are more complex than some have imagined. In order to understand social identification in cases like Philip's, we must explore the interplay between Philip's solidifying identity both within and across events. Because of the indeterminacy of event-level entextualization, we need to know how Philip's identity was established on February 27 and within other events—whether it was consistent with emerging expectations, whether it was normative, and so on. But we must also examine how the identities that emerged on particular days continued or shifted trajectories that were taking shape across events. A trajectory of identification cannot occur without entextualization within events, but identities entextualized within events have no bite over time unless they are incorporated into trajectories. We must examine

empirically the different ways in which trajectories are formed out of events, attending to predictable and unexpected events and to how events come together over time to establish recognizable identities for individuals.

The situation becomes more complicated when we realize that minutes-long events and weeks-long units are not the only timescales across which potentially relevant objectification can happen. Philip was engaged in a process of ontogenetic development, across a timescale of years and decades. At some points in that development, his trajectory of identification would become relatively solid and he would think about and display himself to others as one type of person—perhaps as a “future scientist,” or perhaps as a “burnout”—while at other times his sense of self would be more in flux. Philip’s family was engaged in a process of upward mobility, starting generations ago with the new opportunities his ancestors seized as African Americans emerging from slavery and continuing through him as he chooses a career and raises his own children. Philip was operating in a school institution that involved models of personhood and practices that have developed over centuries, like the expectation that teachers know the right answers and the organization of classrooms with dozens of students working on the same curriculum at the same time. Philip was also identified using models of identity—like “loser”—that have developed sociohistorically and that will also change. I could list other potentially relevant processes that may be relevant to the social identification of Philip in this one science classroom, but these four suffice to make the point. There are many such processes, and no analyst can consider them all.

Following Lemke (2000), I have argued that analysts must do two things in response to this multiplicity of resources and timescales (cf. also Wortham, 2006). First, we must not reduce the phenomenon to one or two relevant timescales. Most interesting human phenomena will be constrained and facilitated by processes at several relevant timescales. Some potentially relevant timescales will not be of interest for understanding the phenomenon of interest. The fact that English is also developing, over centuries, and has certain grammatical categories and phonological registers of potential interest, does not seem to be important to understanding Philip’s social identification in this case. Such timescales should be excluded, in order to make the analysis tractable. But rarely does a phenomenon like Philip’s social identification take place through the exclusive influence of one or two timescales—only those having to do with Philip’s gender, or with his race, or with the details of what happened to him on February 27. An adequate analysis must consider several processes and their interrelations, instead of focusing on “macro,” or “micro,” or a simple relation between the two.

Second, we must appreciate the heterogeneous resources that contribute to social identification or objectification of any sort. If we focus for analytic purposes on social identification in this lab group across two months, we will be unable to understand it without acknowledging the various resources that were required to accomplish it. In this case, for instance, both academic and non-academic resources play an important role. Philip’s local identities depended on the affordances of the lab environment (the fact that only one student could control the apparatus at a time) and the expectations of the curriculum (that there was a right answer and that successful students would figure it out), as well as on widely circulating conceptions of “losers.” Even though our habitual models of knowledge and schooling try to purify the academic by separating off the non-academic (Latour, 1993), in real life these domains are interwoven. In order to understand most interesting things that happen in school, whether they involve academic learning or social identification, we will have to examine both academic and non-academic resources (Wortham, 2001, 2006). In order to study how social identities become objectified, then, we must attend to processes that occur across multiple timescales and to how each of these processes depends on heterogeneous resources.

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